

David Bear: Getting the rail back into rail-trail

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The official reopening of the Big Savage tunnel on Friday will mark an auspicious milestone for the rail-trail known as the Great Allegheny Passage.

Built in 1911 for the Western Maryland Railroad, the 3,300-foot tunnel that burrows through Big Savage Mountain is a major link on the pastoral rail-trail that runs 116 miles along the Youghiogheny and Casselman rivers and tributaries between McKeesport and Frostburg, Md. From Frostburg, another five miles of trail to Woodcock Hollow is completed, and the final nine miles into Cumberland, Md., will be refurbished by this fall. Once in Cumberland, cyclists can connect with the C&O Canal towpath that continue another 185 miles along the Potomac River to Washington, D.C.

This rail-trail is already a world-class route that attracted 400,000 users last year. Annual usage is expected to triple once the connections are complete.

Having spent many happy afternoons over the last 20 years peddling sections of the trails that are now Great Allegheny Passage, I have been looking forward to the longer runs. While the journey from Pittsburgh to Washington represents a major undertaking of at least a week, many riders may prefer shorter two- or three-day trips to Cumberland. A bike/camping expedition is a possibility, as is taking advantage of the new B&Bs, restaurants and other biking-services that have sprung up along the trail.

It's 67 miles from McKeesport to Confluence, a long but fairly level and entirely doable day, especially if you're traveling light. Confluence now boasts several charming accommodation and dining options. From there, it's 63 miles to Cumberland, making for a comfortable weekend trip. For a more leisurely pace, Ohiopyle, Rockwood and Meyersdale offer other mid-route overnight options. (All of these amenities are detailed in the "Trailbook 2006, the 20-Year Commemorative Edition," a handy guide and map published by Fieldstone Press. Copies can be ordered for \$5 plus \$2 shipping at <http://www.atatrail.org/>.)

The major problem with my long weekend plan is getting home. At this point, you can turn around and pedal back -- which adds another two or three days to the trip. You can also arrange to be picked up in Cumberland or leave a vehicle there beforehand, both of which can be complicated and costly.

The irony is that a better option already exists. Amtrak's Capitol Limited parallels the bike route virtually all the way between Washington and Pittsburgh, stopping in a number of towns along the way. Amtrak has reduced the service to one trip a day each way, but the westbound train is scheduled to stop in Cumberland at 7 p.m. and arrive in Pittsburgh at 11:33 p.m. The basic one-way fare is \$27.

Even though Amtrak's schedules can be unreliable, cycling the rail trail one way and returning by railroad would make for a well-rounded experience.

Unfortunately, there's a big hitch in this plan. Although it's possible to ship bikes (in boxes) between Pittsburgh and Washington, Amtrak offers no baggage handling services in Cumberland or any of the other stops in between. So bikes cannot be loaded on board. End of story.

Or maybe not.

Amtrak already offers roll-on roll-off bicycle services and/or bike racks on a few other routes, such as the West Coast Capital Corridor. If there is enough demand from cyclists using the Great Allegheny Passage, would Amtrak add similar services at Cumberland? This would certainly enhance trail usage (and associated tourism) from Pittsburgh and Washington and points in between. Another possibility is having Amtrak provide a dedicated "tourism train" that runs between Pittsburgh and Cumberland.

Ambitious schemes perhaps, but everything starts with an idea. Twenty years ago, who would have thought we'd ever have a 335-mile bike trail between Pittsburgh and Washington?

Trail riders who support Amtrak adding bicycle service or creating a tourism train can register their views at a special e-mail address at the Allegheny Trail Alliance set up for these comments: trainservice@atatrail.org .

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